

Space shuttle

NASA's space shuttle programme was first launched in April 1981, and completed its last mission in 2011. The partly reusable craft taught astronauts an immense amount about working in space.

Which bit is that?

The shuttle had three main components – the orbiter (the plane part, and the only part that went into orbit), a huge fuel tank, and two rocket boosters.



Heat protection

Nearly 25,000 heat-resistant tiles covered the orbiter to protect it from high temperatures on re-entry.



weird or what?

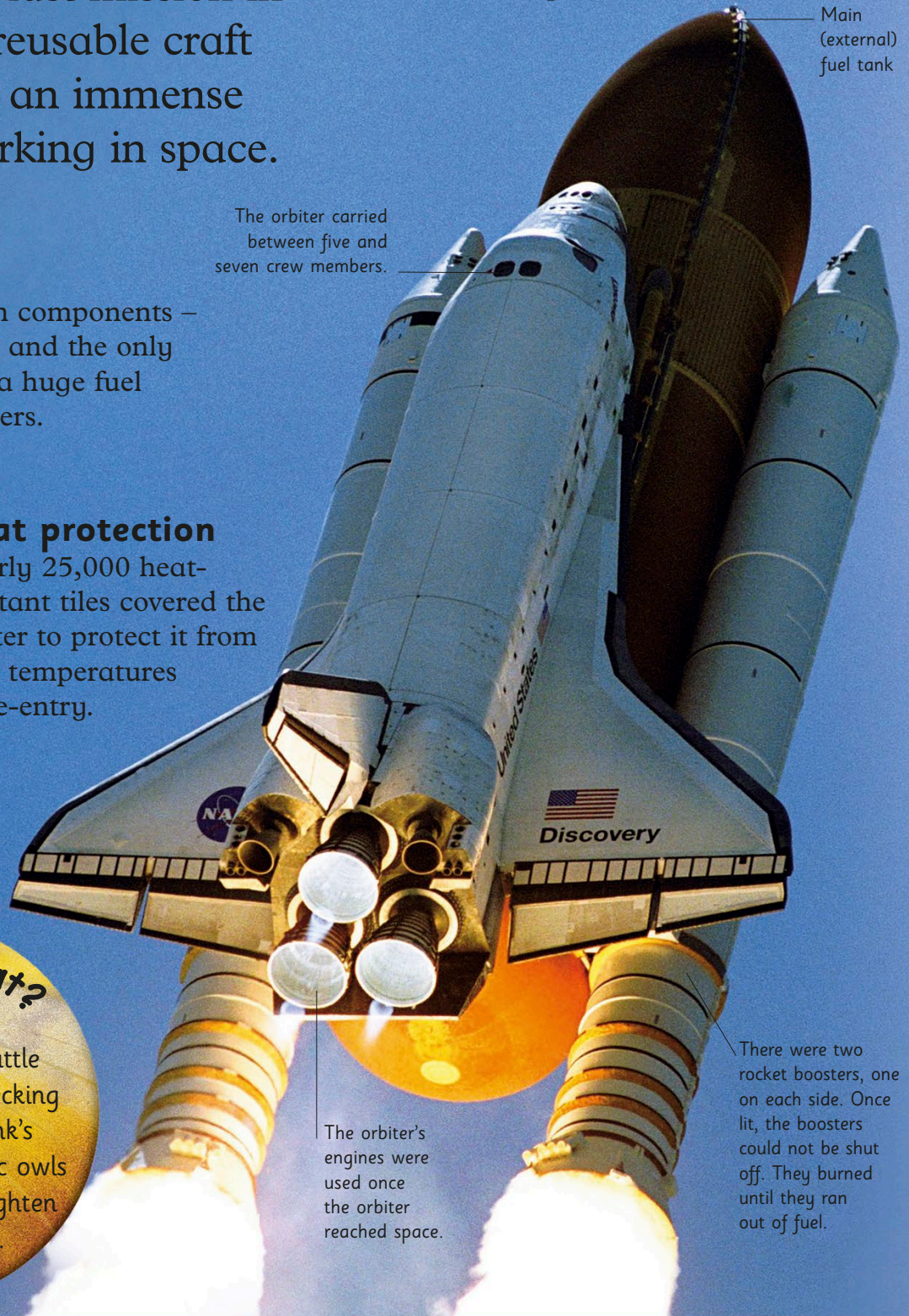
Woodpeckers delayed a space shuttle launch in 1995 by pecking holes in the fuel tank's insulating foam. Plastic owls were later used to frighten other birds away.

Ditch the tanks!

The rocket boosters were released two minutes after launch. They parachuted back to the Earth and would be used again. The tank was discarded eight minutes after launch, and broke up in the atmosphere.

Main (external) fuel tank

The orbiter carried between five and seven crew members.



The orbiter's engines were used once the orbiter reached space.

There were two rocket boosters, one on each side. Once lit, the boosters could not be shut off. They burned until they ran out of fuel.